

COU 5113
Case Study Analysis Assignment Form

Student Name: Ibelice Medina

Instructions: Respond to each section prompt using the following formatting guidelines: no more than 4 paragraphs max per section, single-spaced, typed in Times New Roman 12pt font.

Section 1: Values, Power, Privileges, & Roles

Upon reflecting on my values as a friend but also a counselor in training I have realized that I value compassion and loyalty. Being raised by a Mexican dad born in the “boomer” generation, I was always taught that loyalty and respect would always be the main priority in any scenario. My values push me to keep Tonya’s trust without harming her reputation and help her. However, professionally I am conflicted because of my values as a counselor which are beneficence in actively working for the good of the client and non-maleficence that promotes avoiding harm to clients. My personal and professional values make it difficult to decide whether I choose to be loyal and compassionate towards Tonya or follow my ethical obligations as a future counselor. Being able to recognize that I am struggling with my own biases and judgment is a reminder that prioritizing client welfare and ethical codes are always priority.

As for power and privilege, I have “power” in the sense of having information about erased tapes and a possibility of substance use which cause an ethical responsibility. However, I am also vulnerable if I choose to speak up because I am an intern and telling my supervisor about my concerns could damage my reputation and change the way I am evaluated. Having sensitive information is difficult to manage because I lack authority and credibility from my agency. It also makes me concerned to damage the positive relationship Tonya and the site supervisor have while also damaging ours and be seen as disloyal. The feeling of having power to some extent but also being powerless to the consequences make me hesitate on my judgment.

Lastly, I acknowledge that I have different roles in this scenario. I am a friend to Tonya, an intern, a peer, and most importantly a trainee at an agency that has ethic codes to follow. The friend role pushes me towards being loyal and support my friend, the trainee role knows that setting boundaries with peers is necessary and that reporting unethical client care is necessary. I also realize that both of those dilemmas cannot co-exist at the same time for example, keeping my friends secret on erased tapes conflicts with my role as a responsible counselor in training.

Section 2: Summary of Ethical Decision-Making Process, Decision, and Rationale

As I worked through Corey’s ethical decision-making process model, I first identified problem which is the ethical dilemma of being loyal to Tonya and protection clients as a professional and ethical counselor. Both values matter but only one is in alignment with ACA obligations. After I identified the dilemma, I realized that it was a serious ethical concern that involves competence, client welfare, and a possibility of impairment. Tonya had been erasing videotapes, possibly providing unsafe services, and experimenting with substances to manage her anxiety. I have considered two options regarding which decision to make. The first one is keeping Tonya’s secret, speaking to her privately before going to the site supervisor or going directly to the site supervisor. However, the first option is out of the question because it would conflict with the ACA Code of Ethics starting with Section A, Code A.4.a. Avoiding harm to clients.

After carefully processing this scenario, I realize that the ethical decision that needs to be taken is speaking directly with Tonya. Choosing this course of action allows me to honor her autonomy and give her the opportunity to seek supervision on her own and discussing her

challenges as a trainee. I would let Tonya know I am concerned for her and the client's safety, help her come forward with our supervisors, while reminding her of the consequences if she chooses to ignore the situation. I will also keep in mind that everything must be documented and for that matter, document our conversation in case it is needed in the future because Corey's model states the importance of protecting yourself and anyone involved by documenting.

If Tonya refuses to report to the site supervisor and discuss her possible impairment in consulting clients while also erasing videotapes, my ethical obligation would be to report the situation to the supervisor. The ACA codes that align with this case would be the responsibility to client's welfare (A.1a), avoiding harm (A.4.a.), ensuring competence (C.2.a.), monitoring impairment (C.2.g.), and impairment in which students monitor themselves (F.5.b.). I will also keep in mind that I will also seek supervision to ensure I am taking the right steps into my ethical decision-making model. It is important to analyze my decision with other faculty to discard any biases to my final decision.

Section 3: Reflection

This ethical decision-making model has brought a lot of emotions to me because it is a scenario that could easily happen to anyone in this field. I felt anxious about this situation because I was imagining myself being stuck on this dilemma during my practicum. Debating whether I kept a friend's secret or reporting her behavior was difficult. It was also challenging because at one point, I was thinking of the consequences I could be facing since I am new to seeing clients. Fear was an emotion that weighted heavy on me because I did not want to make the wrong choice. I consider myself to be friendly and I am known to struggle with boundaries because I tend to get attached too quick and prioritize loyalty. This scenario felt personal because I can see myself struggling and second guessing what I should do.

Working through this, I also noticed I felt uncomfortable because I had the realization that my loyalty as a friend was not as important to my responsibility as a professional. It is my ethical obligation to prioritize client's welfare. It taught me important lessons and I was able to learn a lot from this case along with realizing there are challenges where personal values intertwine with professional values. Becoming aware of how easy it is to be involved in dilemmas like this because of boundaries was also important. It was a reminder that strong boundaries are important with my professional relationships not only with clients.

However, discussing this scenario with peers and getting feedback I felt confident in my decision. I did not want to damage our professional relationship which meant speaking to her privately before was the best course of action. I was also relieved in a way knowing that the ACA ethical codes prioritize client welfare. This helped reduced my anxiety on whether I was making the right choice. I felt a lot more confident of knowing what to do if a similar dilemma was to happen during my practicum or internship journey as a counselor in training. It is also great relieve that there is an ethical framework counselors can follow when there are emotions involved in our professional field. This scenario has helped my self-awareness of setting boundaries, clearly understanding my ethical duties and responsibilities, but also knowing that compassion can co-exist with difficult professional decisions.

References

American Counseling Association. (2014). ACA code of ethics.
<https://www.counseling.org/knowledge-center/ethics>